

Name: _____

Period: _____

3.02 - Introducing “On Leaving” and “On Staying Behind” by Diana García

In these paired poems, Diana García gives voice to two women bound by love and separation: a daughter who leaves her homeland in search of a better life, and the mother who stays behind. Both face the same moment of parting — but their experiences of that moment couldn’t be more different.

We’ll use García’s poems as a lens to explore how exigence — a pressing need that calls for a response — can look and feel different depending on perspective.

For one speaker, the urgency might come from survival or opportunity; for the other, from loss, memory, or the painful realization that they may never see their child again.

Why People Leave

Diana Garcia explains in an interview that one of her reasons for writing “On Leaving | On Staying Behind” was to “imagine survival strategies for young women who travel alone in search of a better life”

As you read “On Leaving | On Staying Behind,” think about the exigencies motivating the poet to write and her characters to act, but more importantly, try to see the situation from both perspectives.

Surveying the Text - Group Discussion

- What are your thoughts when you read the titles?
- In which situations might some leave while others stay?
- Discuss the dangers involved in migration.

Key Terms in the poem Defined

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|--|--------------------------------------|
| 1. coyotes: smugglers | 5. serape: cloak or wrap; bedding |
| 2. mis primas: my cousins (female) | 6. endurance: stamina or forbearance |
| 3. la migra: Border Patrol | 7. persists: continues or lasts |
| 4. una profe de los estados unidos: a professor from the United States | 8. fleet: fast or speedy |

Reading for Understanding – Interrupted Reading

For this activity, you will be participating in an interrupted reading of the poem “On Leaving.” This kind of slow reading helps you gain a deeper understanding of a text. I’m going to display two lines from the poem at a time.

After reading the lines, we’ll attempt an analysis as a class, considering Garcia’s word choice (including word connotations), sentence structure, imagery, and anything else that seems important.

Annotate your copy of the poem as we discuss the lines.

On Leaving

By Diana Garcia

1 I can run five times around the village, my dog beside me. I have tested myself against her speed, my younger cousins' endurance. I win.

2 My cousins go with me this morning, their dark hair glossy, so young their shoulders. Their mothers tell me to watch over them.

3 I have said goodbye to all who remain, grayed village elders, wooden statues of saints in our small church, my mother.

4 I go with the blessings of my mother and her sisters. I am the youngest of the girl cousins, no great beauty, no wealth to keep me here.

5 I wear only what I have. I carry a blouse one aunt gave me, a friend's old sandals for days when heat persists into the night.

6 My cousins who have made the journey send this advice: travel early in the morning and at night. When you reach the trains, gain a space.

7 in the middle; don't move. Don't let anyone steal your space. When we reach Mexico, we are to look for coyotes wearing yellow bandanas,

8 not red or green. Those wearing yellow come from our region, they speak our language, they are known to our village.

9 If no one waits at the border wearing yellow, we wait or take our chances. I have waited two years for this chance. No more.

10 If the coyotes separate me from my two cousins, mis primas instruct me to let them take what they will, but not my life, never my life.

11 They think I don't know what they mean. I know what a man can take from a woman. I know my younger cousins' pride.

12 I will protect them from their pride, our family honor. I will scream or fight if I can. I will run if I can. I know now how fast I can run.

On Staying Behind

By Diana Garcia

- 1 She thinks I don't know why she runs. Not to catch the trains
or escape la migra or outrun packs of wild dogs. I listened
- 2 to the advice her cousins sent, the older girl cousins, married,
hard-working girls who left our village with their husbands.
- 3 The journey is harsh, more than two weeks if she's lucky.
So many dangers, only two younger male cousins to protect her.
- 4 My daughter has no husband. She cannot stay with me. I will
not have her stay with me to starve. She leaves with no wealth.
- 5 She and her cousins are their own wealth. I see the strength
in their arms and shoulders, blood that pumps through heart and lungs.
- 6 No water, no beans or corn. Today, the woman studying our village,
una profe de los estados unidos, spilled our pot of beans.
- 7 This woman has never known hunger. I saw her shock when I sifted
beans from dirt, placed beans, dirt, the bit of water I had planned to use
- 8 for grinding the last dried corn. What is a little dirt, I thought, the same dirt
in which I grew these beans. A child should not see a mother starve to death.
- 9 A mother should not hear that her last daughter has disappeared.
I bless this last child, daughter of my heart, the one I hoped
- 10 would wrap my body in a serape and lay me next to her father
at the edge of the church yard. I bless her journey, wishing
- 11 her safe passage, fleet journey. I have said my prayers
to the village saints. I have eaten my small meal. I will lay
- 12 myself alongside her dog tonight. Perhaps tomorrow, more food

will come my way. Again, I stay behind. I will wait and hope.

Partner Discussion - Work With Each Other To Respond to the Following Questions

A. From the Daughter's Perspective

1. What is the daughter responding to? What is the need, pressure, or hope driving her to leave?
 2. How does she describe the moment of departure? What details, images, or emotions reveal what this choice costs her?
 3. What does she seem to gain by leaving? And what does she risk losing?
 4. Which line best shows the daughter's inner conflict or urgency? Why?
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B. From the Mother's Perspective

5. What is the mother responding to? What compels her to stay, even as her daughter leaves?
6. How does the mother describe the separation? What images or memories shape her experience of being left behind?
7. What does staying allow her to hold on to? And what does it force her to endure?
8. Which line best reveals the mother's emotional landscape? What does it show about her relationship to place, family, or history?

As a culminating task (which we'll begin early next week) , you'll write your own pair of poems that capture two perspectives on the *same* situation — two people caught in a single turning point, each responding in their own way.

This could be a friend and a friend, a parent and a child, a teacher and a student, a protester and a bystander — any two voices with conflicting stakes in the same moment.

We'll build plenty of scaffolds and idea banks to help you brainstorm possible situations, define each character's exigence, and experiment with voice, tone, and imagery to make both perspectives feel real and necessary. In the meantime, we'll attempt to see this situation from both perspectives, mother and daughter.

C. Bringing Both Voices Together -

9. How do the two speakers see the same moment differently? Where do their perspectives overlap or diverge?

10. What seems to be at stake for *each* of them?

11. If these two voices were speaking to each other, what might each one want the other to understand?